



August company: Indian pacer Mohammed Shami greets Sri Lankan great Muttiah Muralitharan during the Sportstar Aces Awards function held in Mumbai. K. R. DEEPAK

the world, especially in Pakistan, surfaces would be very flat, whereas in Sri Lanka, it would be a 50-50 wicket that offered equal opportunities to batters and spinners.

So, a lot depends on the teams and what their areas of strength are. Nowadays, when India goes to England, you will get wickets that will swing and seam, whereas when they tour India, the wickets will be according to India's suitability. So, it certainly gets difficult for the teams to adjust to the conditions and go about their business.

England has changed the template of Test cricket with 'Bazball'. What do you make of this new style of play?

I think it's social media and a few people who have made a big deal out of 'Bazball'. For me, it's not a big thing. Test cricket is about five days; the wickets are different, so there's quite a bit of wear and tear, and teams need to bat according to the situation initially. As the wicket is fresh, it offers swing and seam to the bowlers, and for the first three days, teams can bat well, and on the fourth and fifth days, the spinners come into play — that's how the game has been played traditionally.

Much before this concept of 'Bazball' came into existence, Australia was the powerhouse (of such ideas). They tried to score

quickly in the first innings and put up 390-400 runs on the board in the 90 overs. Then, Australia had a strong batting line-up, and they had some top players who could execute these plans. Now, England may display its aggressive style of play at home since the grounds are small, the surfaces are flat, and the outfielders are very fast. Hence, it is possible to play aggressively. But when they come to India or visit other countries, they have to play a different brand of cricket.

'Bazball' does not succeed everywhere. Only when wickets are flat, the outfield is quick, and conditions are in your favour can that concept work, but not always.

In your playing days, India was a powerhouse of spin bowling, with